



Half A Tale

A study in the interrelationship between autobiography and history



Illustrations by **GANESH PYNE**

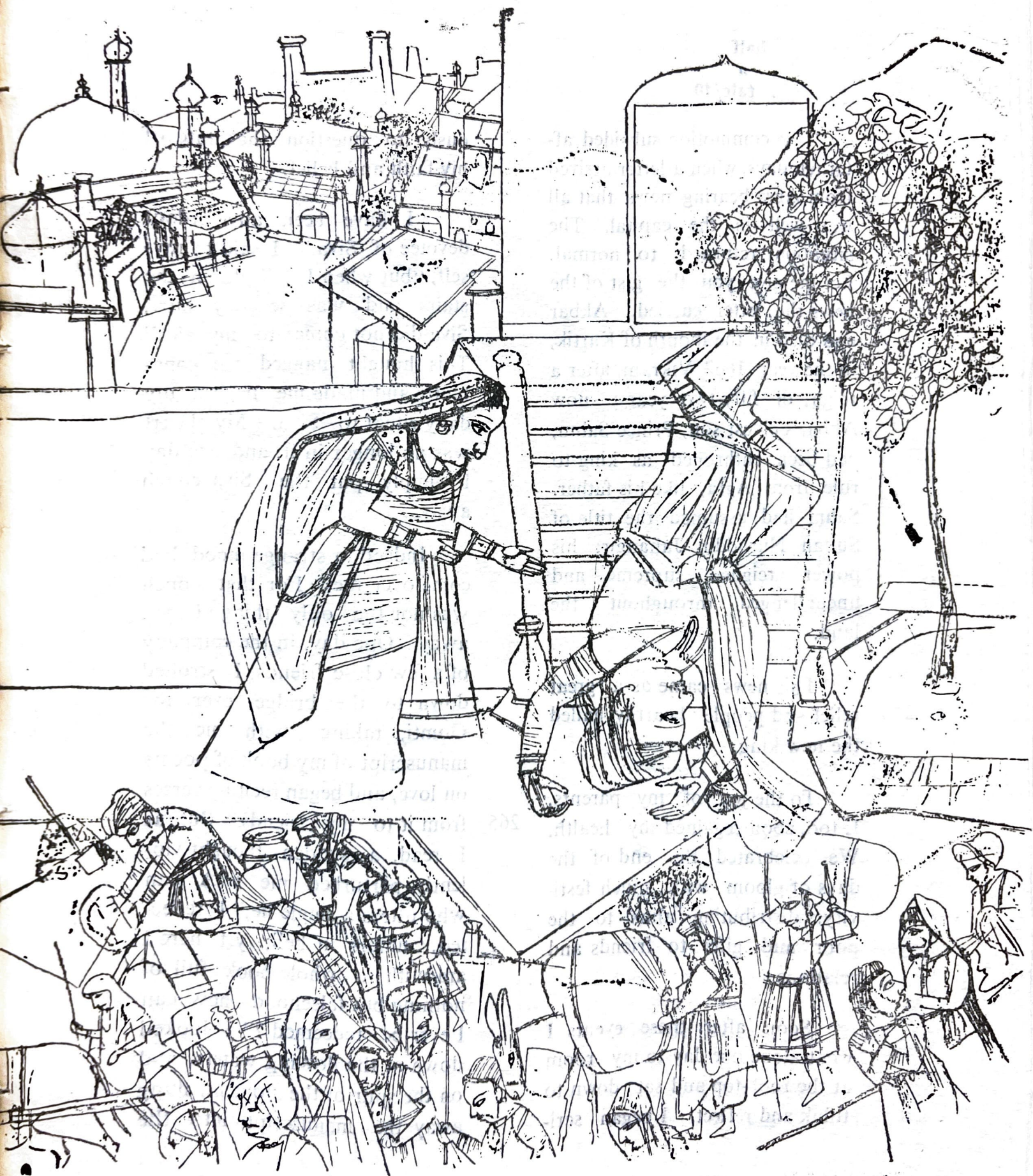
Rajasthan Prakrit Bharati Sansthan, Jaipur

In Vikram 1662 (A.D. 1605), during the month of Kartik, after the monsoon was over, the great emperor Akbar breathed his last in Agra. The alarming news of his death spread fast and soon reached Jaunpur. People felt suddenly orphaned and insecure without their sire. Terror raged everywhere; the hearts of men trembled with dire apprehension; their faces became drained of colour.

I was sitting up a flight of stairs in my house when I heard the dreadful news, which came as a sharp and sudden blow. It made me shake with violent, uncontrollable agitation. I reeled, and losing my balance, fell down the stairs in a faint. My head hit the stone floor and began to bleed profusely, turning the courtyard red. Everyone present rushed to my help. My dear parents were in utter agony. My mother put my head in her lap and applied a piece of burnt

cloth to my wound in order to stop the flow of blood. I was then quickly put to bed with my sobbing mother at my side.

The whole town was in a tremor. Everyone closed the doors of his house in panic; shop-keepers shut down their shops. Feverishly, the rich hid their jewels and costly attire underground; many of them quickly dumped their wealth and their ready capital on carriages and rushed to safe, secluded places. Every householder began stocking his home with weapons and arms. Rich men took to wearing thick, rough clothes such as are worn by the poor, in order to conceal their status, and walked the streets covered in harsh woolen blankets or coarse cotton wrappers. Women shunned finery, dressing in shabby, lustreless clothes. None could tell the status of a man from his dress and it became impossible to distinguish the rich from the poor. There were manifest signs of panic everywhere although there was no reason for it since there were really no thieves or robbers about.



The commotion subsided after ten days, when a letter arrived from Agra bearing news that all was well in the capital. The situation returned to normal. Let me give you the gist of the news the letter carried. Akbar had died in the month of Kartik, in the year 1662 Vikram, after a reign of fifty-two years; now Akbar's eldest son, Prince Salim, had been enthroned as king to rule from Agra, like his father. Salim had assumed the title of Sultan Nuruddin Jahangir; his power reigned supreme and unchallenged throughout the land.

260 This news came as a great relief and people heartily hailed the new king.

To the joy of my parents, I, too, soon regained my health. We celebrated the end of the days of gloom with much festivity, distributing alms to the poor and gifts to friends and relations.

Soon after these events I went alone one day to my room at the roof-top and sat down to think and reflect. I began seri-

ously to question the state of my faith and belief.

"I have been an ardent devotee of Siva," I said to myself, "but when I fell down the stairs and was severely hurt, Siva did not come to my aid." This thought nagged me constantly and made me neglect my daily ritual to Siva. My heart was no longer in it, and one day I simply put the Siva-conch away.

Indeed, a strange mood had come over me. For that conch was not the only thing I put away. One day, in the company of a few close friends, I strolled down to the bridge over the Gomti, taking with me the manuscript of my book of poems on love, and began reciting verses from it to my friends. But as I read, a sudden thought violently perturbed me : "A man who utters a single lie," I reflected, "suffers in hell; yet here I am with a whole book full of nothing but falsehood—how can I ever be redeemed?" I looked down at the flowing waters, and on the spur of the moment, flung away the manuscript into the

river, as though it was so much waste paper. My friends rushed to stop me from this impulsive act, but the deed was done. The folios of my poems were lying scattered over waters running deep and fearful. The book was now beyond retrieval. My friends were greatly distressed, but all they could do was to lament over the quirks of destiny.

My father was glad to hear the news. "Perhaps this is a sign that my son is undergoing a real change for the better," he happily remarked, "there is yet
270 hope for the future of my family."

And, truly, a remarkable change was coming over me. I was like a man transformed. My mind was turning to moral and righteous thoughts. I sincerely began trying to become a religious man in the true sense of the word. And consequently, I gave up my licentious ways to become an upright family man. Rightly has it been said that no amount of effort can make a man give up his aberrant ways. An impetus for reform always comes from within. As a boy

matures, his childishness recedes on its own : as good karma dawns, evil karma slinks away naturally.

I had now become a genuine adherent of the religion to which I was born. The first thing I did every morning was to visit a Jain shrine, not even waiting to brush my teeth before paying homage to the enshrined Tirthankara. I strove diligently to put the precepts of my faith to practice and follow the fourteen prescribed rules of conduct (niyama). I performed the decreed penances for the expiation of sins, and sat religiously for the enjoined samayika meditations which have been designed to instill an attitude of detachment towards the world in a man. I gave up eating green vegetables, for these are forbidden to a Jain, and took a vow never to touch brinjals and other prohibited food for the rest of my life. For eight days in a year I observed the special ritual of paying homage to the Tirthankaras, singing hymns to
275 their glory and imploring them for grace and mercy. I had truly become a devout, faithful

Jain and spent hours listening to the religious lore of Jainism.

Who could have predicted such a sudden conversion? Unfathomable, indeed, is the mind of man and none can ever foresee the path it might next choose to follow. I had been a man of ignominious ill-repute, but now my conduct was commended by all.

I have been telling you, so long, of events that occurred before the year Vikram 1664. Let me now give you a brief summary of events that happened in 1664 itself.

I had two sisters. The elder was married and lived in Jaunpur. The younger was still unmarried. My family was anxiously looking for a suitable groom for her. In 1664 she was at last wedded and went with her husband to live in Patna. The wedding took place in the spring month of Phalgun.

Another son was born to me this year, but he, too, did not live for more than a few days.

Like a parrot
He flew away
Leaving behind an empty
cage
His lifeless frame.

The next three years were rather uneventful. Time passed with its usual share of joy and sorrow and I continued in my good, reformed ways, causing much happiness to my father.

In Vikram 1667 my father decided to send me on a trading mission to Agra. He purchased a sizeable amount of saleable goods in addition to merchandise he already had in his possession and directed me to take them to Agra to market them as profitably as I could. Taking a piece of paper he drew up a proper list of all the goods he had assembled and set down the price of each article. It was quite a miscellany. Firstly, there were precious stones, loose as well as set in ornaments: I had twenty-four pieces of rubies, nine sapphires, twenty emeralds, thirty-four sundry jewels, four bags of stone-dust (chunni), two bracelets and two finger-rings. Then there was ghee, weighing

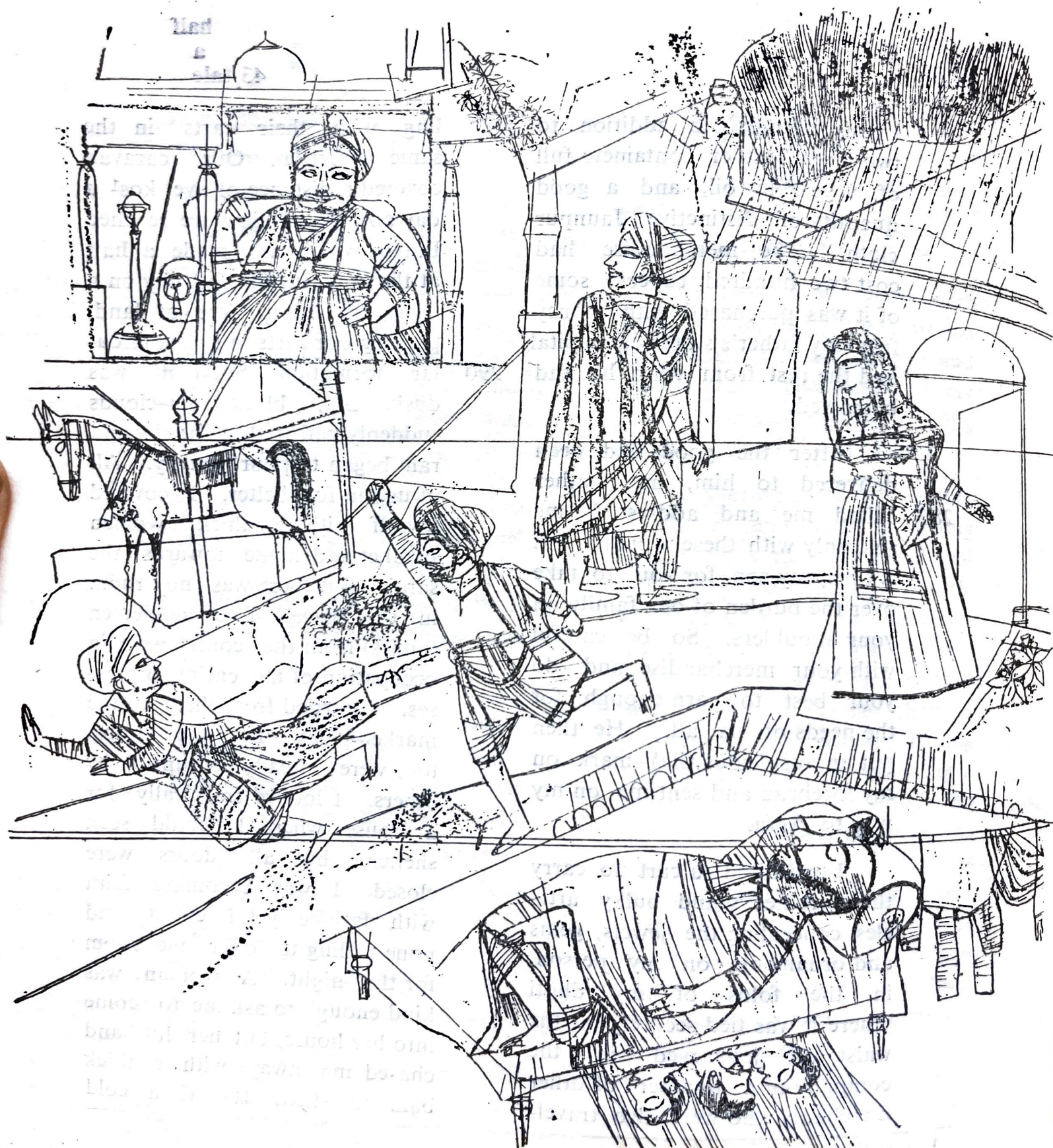
twenty maunds, in addition to two large, leather containers full of vegetable oil, and a good quantity of distinctive Jaunpur cloth. The merchandise had cost two hundred rupees; some of it was purchased with money from my father's stored-up capital and the rest from what he had borrowed.

285 After the goods had been delivered to him, my father called me and addressed me solemnly with these words: "It is time, my son, for you to take over the burden of our family on your shoulders. So be careful with your merchandise and do your best to earn enough for the needs of us all." He then put an auspicious tilak-mark on my forehead and sent me on my way to Agra.

I had hired a cart to carry the more heavy and bulky articles, concealing the jewels, gems and ornaments on my person, in the folds of my dhoti where it was tied securely at the waist. I journeyed in the company of a number of other merchants who were also travel-

290 ling with their carts in the same direction. Our caravan covered a distance of five kos¹ a day and in due time we reached Etawa where we made a halt at the outskirts of the city on a large, flat, open piece of land, parking our carts in a close circular formation. Soon it was dusk. Big, black rain-clouds suddenly gathered in the sky and rain began to pour heavily. All of us ran for shelter. I covered myself with a thick woolen blanket and made towards the sarai. But there was no room in the place. Two noblemen (amirs) from the court were in occupation of the entire premises. I hurried from there to the market-place. But the shops, too, were already occupied by others. I looked frantically for a house where I could seek shelter, but all doors were closed. I was becoming faint with fatigue yet I could find none willing to offer me room for the night. A woman was kind enough to ask me to come into her house, but her husband chased me away with a thick bamboo stick. It was a cold

¹ One kos is about 2 miles.



dark night, for this was the
winter month of Agrahayana
and my feet were heavy with
295 the gluey mud on the roads

I was wretched and had
nowhere to go. At last, in des-
peration, I proceeded to the city
gate. Outside the gate there
was a small hut occupied by
some sentries. I had two other
Jains with me; the three of us
approached this hut and pleaded
with the sentries for shelter. The
sentries demanded to know who
we were, and we told them that
we were merchants travelling with
a caravan looking for shelter for
the night; we added that we had
searched all over the town in
vain and now had nowhere to
go. We beseeched them to take
pity on our plight and give us
room for the night. The sentries
were moved to kindness and
asked us to enter the hut, saying
that they would be leaving soon
and we could have the hut to
ourselves for the night. But they
warned us that we would have
to face a little problem in the
morning when accosted by the
300 city authorities, and only a good

bakshish¹ would help us out.
We agreed to this condition,
happy at last to find a roof over
our head. I fetched some water,
washed my feet and hung my
wet clothes to dry. We then
spread some hay on the floor
and the three of us lay down to
sleep. We had hardly been able
to close our eyes when a hefty,
grim-faced man appeared on
the door of the hut and deman-
ded that we get out of the hut;
he claimed that it was his pro-
perty.

"You cannot stay here," he
shouted angrily, "this is my hut.
I sleep here on my cot every
night. If you do not get up and
leave immediately, I will give
you a good whipping and drive
you out forcibly."

Terrified, we got up ins-
tantly, and, collecting our things,
trudged out into the rain once
again. But as he watched us
walk away wearily, the man
took pity on us and called us
back to him. He spread a mat
made of jute on the floor and
put his cot on it.

1 Literally 'bestowment', a tip or a small bribe.

305 "I cannot sleep without a
cot," he said, "but you may
sleep on the mat under the cot
if you like."

We had no choice but to
accept his grudging offer. No
man can escape his karma; how
could we? As we sow, so we
reap, and everything is impelled
by karma. The cloth we weave
is made of the yarn we have
spun ourselves.

And so our rough intruder
slept on the cot while we ill-fated
travellers slept under it. But
fortunately we were able to
sleep soundly as the blankets we
carried kept us warm. As soon
as it was morning, we returned
to our carts. The rain had
stopped and our caravan could
be on the move once again.

Finally, we reached Agra.
It was raining the day we arrived
there and the roads were slippery
with mud. Now travelling
alone, I crossed the river and
went into the town, leaving my
bales of cloth and the drums of
oil and ghee behind on the other

310 bank. I wondered where I
should stay and with whom. I
decided to go to Bandidas, who
was my younger sister's husband,
for as the saying goes, there are
two categories of men on whom
one can always rely, namely,
saints and close relatives. ✓

Bandidas lived in Moti Katla ✓
near the house of Champsi, a
well-known citizen. He wel-
comed me warmly and expressed
concern about where I had left
my bales of cloth and my drums
of oil and ghee. I told him I
had stored them safely in the
premises of a business firm
(kothi)¹ across the river.

After a few days I rented a
place of my own and fetched my
bales of cloth there. I then
began to visit the market-place
daily, and within a few days
succeeded in selling my entire
stock of cloth. But when I drew
up the final accounts, I dis-
covered that I had been a loser
because, after deducting interest,
the money that I had made
turned out to be less than the
original outlay.

¹ Literally, 'a house', 'kothi' is the Hindi term for a business firm. The word is also used, as in this case, for the premises where the firm has its offices.

One day, soon after I had sold my stock of cloth, I crossed the river to the other bank where my stock of ghee and oil was stored. I sold my entire stock 315 of both these commodities, making a profit of four rupees. The hundi¹ against which my father had borrowed money earlier in Jaunpur had now fallen due. I received it and paid out the required sum.

Now that I had sold my bulkier goods, I ventured to sell my gems. I was proving to be a poor businessman. Indiscriminately, I handed over articles to people purely on trust, without finding out whether the man I was dealing with was really trustworthy. Many dealers took advantage of this misplaced trust and never came back to pay me for the things they had taken. Some even misused my jewels as a pledge to borrow money for their own purpose and never paid me anything at all. I was utterly naive and untutored in the devious ways of the Agra market. My deals miscarried

and I began to lose money heavily.

I also lost money through sheer bad luck. One day, when I was out in the town, the string with which my pajama was tied to my waist suddenly broke. I had concealed a necklace of pearls as well as my entire stock of loose gems in the fold made for the string; all my precious articles fell out and were irretrievably lost. I also lost my rubies in a similar manner. I had kept them tied to the string of one of my pajamas which I left hanging on a clothes-line in my room. Some rats gnawed away at the pajama-string in my absence one day and made away with my rubies. I suffered these grave losses silently, never speaking of 320 them to anyone.

But this was not yet the end of my losses. I had still more to suffer. I have said earlier that in my stock of jewellery there was a pair of gem-studded bracelets. I sold these and received a reasonable price for them; but a

1 A bill of exchange or a promissory note. Here it denotes the latter. In traditional business practice the borrower makes out a hundi to the lender for the sum stipulating the agreed interest and the period within which the money is to be repaid.

revenue collector appropriated the money and I had to write it off as a dead loss. I had now only one costly article left: a jewelled finger-ring; I managed to lose this too. I dropped it somewhere while I was tying it with a knot to a piece of string. Now I had nothing left but odds and bits of paltry things: an insignificant quantity of gold and silver, a bundle of cloth and two angarkhas (men's upper garments). The evil karma of my past had come to afflict me with a vengeance. In addition to my other travails, I fell ill, running extremely high temperature. I
325 began to fast and ate nothing whatever for ten days. Then I took to medicines, keeping myself on a restricted diet. It was long before I regained health. I had been unable to visit the market-place for a whole month.

All these days I had been receiving numerous letters from my father, but I had not dared to write to him anything at all about myself. However, he came to know of my ill-fortunes through my brother-in-law,

Uttamchand, the son of Dulah, and the husband of the elder of my two sisters. Uttamchand was at that time living in Agra and practising trade in precious stones. He wrote back home saying that I had lost all my money and had become a pauper—an act not expected of a friend. This news travelled fast to my father in Jaunpur, who was hurt to the quick and began to lament his fate bitterly. He rushed home and told my mother the whole miserable story, blaming her and railing at her for what had passed, charging her with having insisted on sending me on this luckless venture.

330 “Did I not tell you even then that this boy will return home a beggar?” he raged. “Alas, my words have come unfailingly true. Our shameless son has at last ruined us. He has cut us at our roots. We have now nothing left with which to do business ever again.” He vituperated against me relentlessly, calling me names till his breath became heavy with unbearable despair. When he had done with his shouting, he had



my wife packed off to her father in Khairabad.

Meanwhile at Agra I was trying to squeeze a living out of the little I had left. I sold my silver and gold and every little thing I still had, and was finally left with no more than a few coins. I stopped visiting the market-place; in fact, I stopped moving out of my room at all.

But I spent my evening singing and reciting poems. A small group of about ten people
335 used to visit me regularly and to

them I sang *Madhumalati* and *Mirgavati*, two narrative ballads on love. My visitors greatly enjoyed my singing and conversation.

My evenings were thus spent pleasantly, though I was so miserably poor that I had nothing to eat the next morning. One of my regular visitors was a halwai who sold kachauris—a kind of stuffed, salted pancake. I bought large quantities of kachauris from this man's shop on credit. If I ever moved out of my room, it was to go to his kachauri shop,

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for I was subsisting on these kachauris, eating nothing else. I ate kachauris for all my meals, breakfast, lunch or dinner; often eating them cold or even stale. My halwai friend was unaware of my true circumstances. But one
340 day, when I was alone with him, I told him all, confessing that I had no money left with me and that I even owed a lot. I warned him not to give me any more kachauris for he might never get his money back.

The halwai was a kindly soul. He gave me leave to eat kachauris worth twenty rupees from his shop, assuring me that

he would not bother me for money. We kept this agreement a secret. None of my other visitors came to know of my true state of affairs. My evening sessions continued. The rest of the day I spent alone, with none but myself for company.

I lived for over six months in this manner. Then, suddenly one night, Tarachand Tambi, son of Parbat Tambi and a brother of my father-in-law, appeared at my place. Without a word he sat down, unobtrusively in the company of my other
345 visitors. Only when everyone had left did he address me and



his words were full of love and regard. He invited me to his house for lunch the next day and would not take no for an answer, though I had no mind to go. Next morning he came again to fetch me and implored me, saying that the meal was ready and I should not tarry. He said that I could go later, after the meal, to the market-place for my work if I wanted to.

His invitation was only a ruse to take me to his house. For as soon as I was there, he sent a man to my room to fetch my meagre belongings. He also
350 had my rent, which was long-due, paid. He then implored me to stay with him, and so stubbornly did he insist that I had no choice but to give in.

So I began living comfortably in his house, doing nothing at all for the next two months. Then I ventured into business afresh, this time in partnership with a man called Dharamdas, an Oswal Jain originally from Delhi. Dharamdas was the youngest brother of Jasu and Amarsi, who were flourishing merchants dealing in precious stones.

Dharamdas was the dark sheep of the family. He kept bad company and had acquired many odious habits : he was a spendthrift and overfond of opium. In view of his waywardness we drew up a proper deed of partnership and duly affixed it with our signatures before setting up business. A sum of rupees five hundred was put up as capital by Dharamdas' brothers.

Dharamdas proved to be a good partner for me, and we worked in harmony like two close friends, earnestly building up a modest trade in precious stones. We were busy from morning to night walking up and down the Agra bazar, ever on the lookout for profitable deals.
355 Gradually we set up a brisk trade in rubies, manis and the dust of precious stones (chunni). We maintained proper ledgers of account and always kept them up-to-date, regularly entering our daily transactions in our books. People came to know us and place their trust in us and we began to make enough money for a reasonably good living.

I had now enough money to repay what I owed my friend, the halwai. The debt amounted to fourteen rupees and I paid it in three instalments. The halwai was happy to get his money back.

I continued with this partnership for two years. Then, becoming dissatisfied with it, I decided to give it up and go to Khairabad. I went to Jasu Sah, Dharamdas' elder brother, and told him of my decision to leave Agra, handing over to him the bag of precious stones that now formed our total asset. Jasu
360 Sah asked me to sell the stones and obtain cash, which I promptly did. I paid him back the five hundred rupees he had invested in the partnership, not keeping a single unearned paisa for myself.

It was in the year Vikram 1670 that I wound up my partnership with Dharamdas, ending it formally, as it had begun, after duly drawing up all the required papers. In the two years that the partnership lasted,

I had made over two hundred rupees. But it had all been consumed in expenses, and at the end I had no earnings left. The hard months of toil and effort had come to naught, yielding not even a single cowrie-shell. I had churned an ocean to obtain but a snail. Like the proverbial hing-seller,¹ I sat down quietly to take stock of my gains only to discover that
365 I had foolishly lost all. For a whole year I had danced a mad dance for the sake of money but in the end I was as empty-handed as before.

Yet fortune did grant me a small favour before I left Agra. I was walking down a lane near my home one day, when I espied a small packet lying on the street. I immediately picked it up and quickly walked back home. The packet contained eight pearls, the sight of which thrilled me beyond measure; I felt I had found the magic gem which grants all desire. I had a hollow talisman made for myself and hid the pearls in it. I tied this talisman to my waist, con-

1 Banarasi is referring to a didactic tale or fable popular in his day. We are unable to trace it or learn its details.

370 cealing it with great care and caution, and set out from Agra, journeying to the east. Soon I reached Khairabad, where I went straight to my father-in-law Kalla Sah's¹ house.

It was evening when I arrived there, and at night my wife asked me how I had been faring in Agra. I lied to her, giving her the impression that I was doing very well. But she could see through my lies and rebuked me.

"Why do you boast and bluff?" she said.

I then had to tell her the truth and confessed that I was left with nothing.

"I spent all I earned," I said, "and now I have not a paisa with me."

My wife tried to console me. "God gives man both joy and sorrow," she said. "For you this has been a period of suffering. Happiness, too, will come in its time. Fate must run its course and man must reap the

fruits of both his sins and his piety."

375 All through the night we talked of my life in Agra. In the morning, as I was sitting alone, my wife came to me secretly and gave me twenty rupees, telling me that it was money she had saved for a day of need; it could, she said, be of use to me now that I was having a difficult time.

"Do not despair, my husband," she added, "for if a man lives he can yet achieve everything."

Later, she took her mother aside and told her everything in confidence, adding by way of caution that it was to be kept a secret from everybody.

"O mother," she beseeched her, "as I am your daughter, help me in my need. My very honour is at stake. If you cannot do something within a few days, my husband is sure to leave us and go away. Though he does not utter a word, he is tormented with shame and humiliation."

1 Shortened form of Kalyanmal Tambi.

Her mother soothed her, telling her not to lose heart. She had, she said, two hundred rupees hidden away in savings which she promised to give me secretly without anyone getting to know a word about it. She advised her to ask me to go again to Agra and begin work anew. My wife thanked her mother profusely, promising that she would quietly try to fathom my intentions that night when alone with me and persuade me
380 to adopt the course of action her mother had suggested.

That night she was very sweet to me and questioned me gently about my future plans :

"What do you want to do now ?" she asked. "Do you want to stay here or are you planning to go somewhere else ?"

"Let us both go to Jaunpur," I proposed.

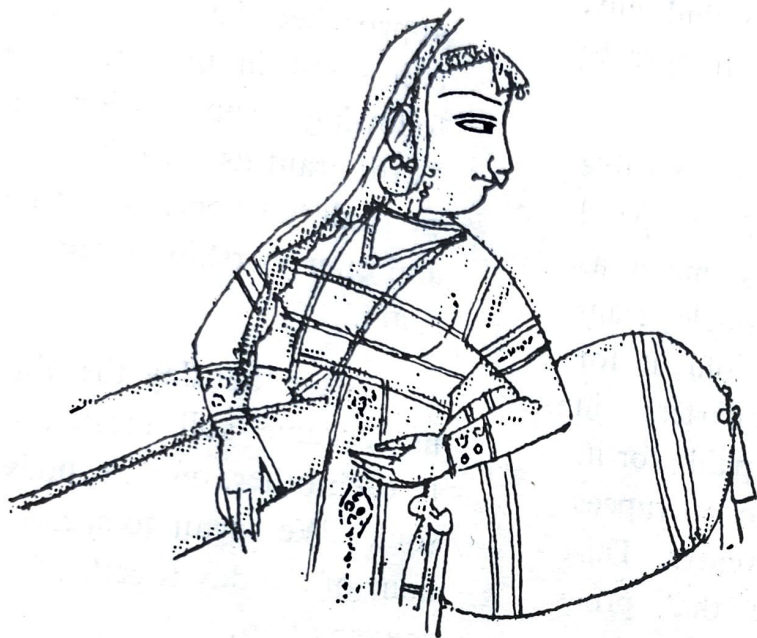
But she dissuaded me. "Jaunpur is in a turmoil afflicted with a hundred troubles. Why not go to Agra once again ? That is the right place for you at this time."

"But what will I do there without money ?" I protested. "A poor man can achieve nothing. His life is not worth living."

She then gave me new hope with this promise and assurance :
"Go buy all the merchandise you need. I will give you the necessary capital."

With these words she went in and brought me the two hundred rupees her mother had given her for me. The whole matter was kept secret from everyone else.

I became infused with new life. With fresh enthusiasm, I launched upon a number of activities all at once. I began to buy quantities of cloth with a view to market it and made arrangements for having it properly washed and cleaned. I also scanned the market for more precious articles such as
385 pearls, rubies and diamonds. I resumed my writing and began work on two books simultaneously, namely, *Ajitanatha ke Chand* and *Namamala*, both in verse.



I was doing things with a renewed vitality and was able to find time for all my four projects : the writing of two books and the purchase of two different sets of merchandise. Within four months I had completed all my projects. I finished work on the *Namamala* which contains two hundred verses. I also completed *Ajitanatha ke Chand*. My stock of cloth was duly washed and ready for the market, and I had succeeded in acquiring a good necklace of pearls.

Then, in the month of Agrahayana, on the twelfth day of

the waxing moon, I set out for Agra again. This was my second visit to the town, and I carted my goods to the market known as Katla Parvez, where my father-in-law had a trading establishment (hat), deciding to operate from there. Arrangement for my meals was made at my father-in-law's establishment, where I also slept at night in the rooms used as the office. Every morning I went to the marketplace, trying to find a buyer for my things. But this proved to be a difficult proposition, for the cloth I had was of inferior quality. I sweated a good deal, running about in search of good

buyers, but failed to find any. Alas, I was still a stranger to the ways of fortune !

But I made a remarkable profit on the sale of my pearl necklace, earning as much as thirty rupees in that single transaction. The price I sold it for was a full-three quarters in excess of what I had paid for it. I had bought it for forty rupees and sold it for seventy. This success convinced me that profits were to be had only in gems and precious stones. I tried untiringly for four whole months to sell my cloth but my efforts were of no avail. The stock lay like a dead weight around my feet.

395 I had made two good friends, both very close and dear to me. One was Narottamdas, the grandson of Benidas of the Khobra gotra. The other was Thanmal Badaliya. The three of us were greatly attached to each other. We made a merry
trio, spending all our time in each other's company.

One day, taking a carriage we went together to offer worship at a Jain shrine. After performing the usual rites of propi-

tiation, the three of us approached the deity with folded palms and, in unison, made the following supplication : "O Lord, grant us wealth, for then we shall have occasion to come and offer worship at your shrine again."

After that day the three of us became still more attached to each other, one in body and soul. We began to spend every hour of the day together in sweet conversation.

Then, during that year, in the spring month of Phalgun, a rich friend of ours named Tarachand Mothiya, who was a son of Nema, invited me to join him in a marriage party which was soon to proceed out of town. Balchand was the groom. Narottamdas was travelling with it and I, too, was prevailed upon to go. I began to look for some money to take with me, and sold a few pearls which I had put aside for bad times. They fetched me thirty-two rupees, which
400 sum I took with me on my journey.

When I returned I had no money left. I hastened to sell



my stock of cloth for whatever I could get and had to be satisfied with four rupees less than my cost price. I used this money to pay off some interest that had fallen due. I was free of debt but a pauper once again.

I went to see Narottam at his house. He welcomed me warmly and forced me to share his meal. I told him I was bankrupt, with nothing left and nowhere to go. He implored me to come and live with him. He assured me

that I was like a brother to him and that whatever was his was also mine. His house, he added, was always open to those whom he loved. I was hesitant and protested that others in his family, especially his wife, may not like my being there. But he silenced me with these words : "Can you think of anyone in my family who will say anything to hurt you ?"

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He insisted and I could not refuse. He now made it a habit

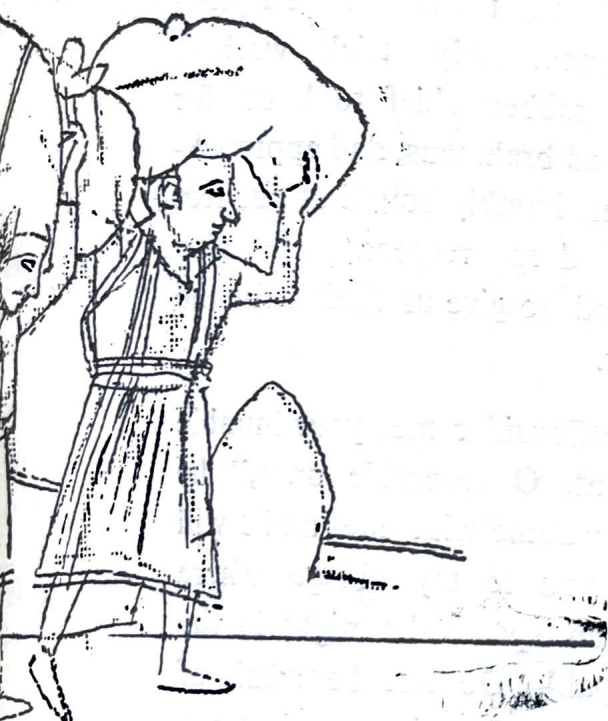
to address me as 'brother'; he also treated me like one, and we were always inseparable.

One day, when Narottamdas

was with Tarachand Mothiya, Tarachand offered him some work. He asked Narottam to travel as his agent to Patna, taking me with him. He gave



us money and we began making preparations for our departure. Then, on an auspicious day, we performed the propitiatory rites customary for people setting out



half
a
59/tale

on a long journey and crossed the Yamuna with tilak-marks on our foreheads.

We were three of us, Narottam, I, and his father-in-law: all young, able Sriminal men. We hired a carriage for our journey but took no serving men.

We had hired our carriage at Firozabad and we were to travel on it upto Shahzadpur, about half way on the road to Patna. When we reached Shahzadpur we paid our fare 410 and decided to cover the rest of the journey on foot, hiring a porter to carry our luggage.

We decided to leave Shahzadpur as early in the morning as possible. That night, about five hours after sunset, the moonlight suddenly became very bright and we were deceived into thinking that day was about to dawn. So we immediately set out on our way. But as the light was yet dim, we could not properly make out our path. We strayed towards the south and soon entered a thick forest. It was not long before we realized that we were completely lost in the middle of a desolate

jungle. Our porter suddenly lost his wits and began to scream and howl in panic. He threw down the luggage he was carrying and ran away into the wilderness. We had no choice but to carry the load ourselves. We divided it into three bundles, one for each of us. But the journey now became an ordeal. We tried to ease our burden by constantly shifting the weight from head to shoulders, but this was hardly of any help. Soon it was midnight and yet we were still far away from anywhere. We were miserable and almost demented with fatigue, singing and crying in the same breath like men who have suddenly gone mad.

After a little while, we entered a part of the forest where robbers lived in little hamlets of their own. A man espied us and shouted: "Who goes there?" We were seized with terror. Our lips were parched and suddenly glued together. We could not bring ourselves to utter a single word and began fervently to pray to God.

The man we had encountered was the chief of the robbers himself. Seeing him, I had a timely inspiration. I pronounced a benediction upon the man, chanting a sacred verse in Sanskrit in the manner of a pious brahman. My trick worked. The robber chief took us for learned brahmans, and approaching us, humbly bowed at our feet with deep respect. He also offered to give us shelter for the night.

"Consider me your humble servant, O venerable ones," he said. "Come with me and I will take you to my village where you can spend the night in the chaupal.¹ Do not be afraid of me, for as God is my witness, I mean you no harm."

We quietly followed the robber chief to his village, and, true to his word, he gave us a place for the night.

But we were still trembling 420 violently with fear, our hearts pounding and our faces drained of all colour. As soon as we were alone, we hurriedly hunted

1 A place where villagers meet to sit and gossip or conduct business. It is also used as a shelter for guests or travellers.



for some loose yarn and quickly spun it into four sacred threads (janeu)¹ such as every brahman must wear. We then hung three

of the sacred threads across our shoulders, and kept the fourth conspicuously out for all to see. Then, fetching some mud and a

¹ The sacred thread worn by high caste Hindus. Banarasi, being a Jain, had no janeu. Even high caste Hindus do not strictly observe the rule of wearing it, but for a brahman engaged in sacred studies, such as Banarasi and his friends were pretending to be, a janeu was a must.

little water from a nearby pond, we smeared our foreheads with holy tilak-marks befitting pious brahmans. Our disguise now complete, we waited quietly for the morning to come. But we were still seized with fear and remained huddled together in a crouching position till about six hours later when light dawned and the rising sun turned the clouds red.

The robber chief approached us on a horse with a retinue of twenty men. When he came near us, he folded his palms and deeply bowed his head in veneration. I blessed him, again loudly intoning a sacred benedictory verse.

"Come venerable brahmans, let me lead you out of the forest and show you the road," the chief said.

Obediently, we followed him with our bundles on our head. The man meant well and took us along a path that led out of the
425 forest. After we had walked for

about three kos, we reached the road to Fatehpur.

"This road will take you to your destination," the robber chief assured us. Pointing to a clump of trees in the distance, he added: "There, across those trees, lies Fatehpur."

He then begged leave of us and we blessed him heartily, chanting "May you live long," and began to walk towards Fatehpur.

We could soon glimpse the town of Lakhraun at a distance. It was about two kos away. Another two kos from there was Fatehpur, where we made a halt and hired two porters to carry our luggage for the onward journey towards Allahabad, which was six kos away. There we decided to take a longer rest. We put our things in a sarai and went to the ghat¹ on the bank of the Ganga where we took our meals.

I now walked down alone into the city to meet my father,

1 A stone or brick platform built on a river bank with steps leading down to the water. In important centres of pilgrimage such as Prayag, ghats are almost like market-places with shops catering to the various needs of the huge crowds of pilgrims that gather there for a ritual bath.